

Lirael Scatterstar

The sun had just begun to sink beneath the horizon, painting the sky in hues of orange and purple, as Lirael Scatterstar emerged from the grand edifice of her family's ancestral home. All day she had been ensnared by the stifling obligations of her noble lineage. Endless meetings with stuffy nobles, dutifully nodding along to their labyrinthine discussions about trade and alliances.

Lirael slipped away from her ancestral manor in the city of Hillsfar, donning a simple cloak to shield her from the cool night air. A hushed sigh escaped her lips as she darted through the narrow alleyways, the tight corridors of stone gradually giving way to open fields. A radiant grin graced her lips as she finally felt the cool grass beneath her feet, the city's dull chatter replaced by the rhythmic chorus of the evening forest.

Moonlight filtered through the canopy, illuminating patches of the undergrowth. The forest hummed with life, a symphony of night sounds that echoed in the stillness. Lirael walked farther, her magical senses guiding her deeper into the woods. Her blood hummed, answering the wild's call, a subtle echo of her fey lineage.

As she ventured deeper, Lirael began to feel a shift, a harmonic resonance that only those of fey-blood could sense. She followed it, her body moving almost of its own accord, drawn by an unseen force.

Finally, she arrived in a glade bathed in moonlight, a serene pond nestled in its heart, mirroring the twinkling stars above. Lirael sank to her knees, pressing her palms into the cool, damp earth. Closing her eyes, she allowed the energy of the wild to wash over her, seeping into her very essence. The air seemed to shimmer, a faint luminescence surrounding her as her fey-blood responded to the wild magic coursing through the area.

The voices of the fey, usually hushed and whisper-like, grew stronger in the stillness of the night. They sung tales of ancient days and echoed her ancestors' deeds, their voices blending into a harmonious lullaby that resonated with the rhythm of the forest.

Each note, each whispered word, fed her spirit and reaffirmed her purpose. Here, amidst the untamed wilds, she wasn't just Lirael of House Scatterstar; she was Lirael, the fey-blooded, the protector of the wild spaces, the voice of the fey.

With a final sigh of contentment, she opened her eyes, her gaze meeting the myriad stars above. Lirael felt renewed, her fey spirit singing in tune with the forest around her. Even as she prepared to return to the confines of her city life, she knew she would carry the echoes of this night with her, a fey lullaby forever etched in her soul.

As she turned back towards Hillsfar, she bore a renewed sense of purpose. She would navigate the intricate web of nobility, uphold her family's legacy, but she would never forget her true nature, the fey blood that coursed through her veins. Because it was that connection, that sense of being a part of something vast and beautiful, that truly made her who she was. And no noble obligation, no city walls, could ever change that.

Upon her return to the grand Scatterstar mansion, Lirael was met with furrowed brows and disappointed glances. Her mother, the elegant and stern-faced Aralind, was waiting for her in the main hall, a frown creasing her usually smooth forehead.

"Lirael, you can't keep wandering off like this. You have responsibilities here, obligations to your family and to Hillsfar. You're not a child anymore," Aralind admonished, her gaze hardening as she looked at her daughter.

Beside Aralind stood Lirael's grandmother, Seraphina. Although her body was frail and her hair silver, the fire in her eyes was as fierce as ever. "Your mother's right, Lirael. You're a Scatterstar, not some hedge witch. Your place is here, in the city, not gallivanting about in the woods."

Lirael's gaze dropped to the floor. "I understand, mother, grand-mère. It won't happen again," she said, her voice carrying the weight of her regret.

The next morning, Lirael woke early, her first task for the day bringing breakfast to her great-grandmother, Miriel. The last fey-touched Scatterstar before Lirael, Miriel lived in a quiet wing of the mansion, her room overlooking the wildflower gardens that she loved so much.

Upon entering, Lirael was met with Miriel's warm smile. Her great-grandmother's bright eyes, the emerald mirror to Lirael's own, twinkled with an inner light as she gestured for Lirael to join her by the window. Setting down the breakfast tray, Lirael complied, her eyes following Miriel's gaze out over the garden.

"I know where you were last night, Lirael," Miriel began, her voice soft but firm. Lirael's heart sank, but before she could speak, her great-grandmother held up a hand. "Don't worry, my dear. I'm not here to scold you. I was just like you once, drawn to the wilds, to the magic in our blood. But listen to me now," she said, turning to look at Lirael, "I've felt something in the wind, a change in the sea breeze. The fey, our kin, are restless."

Lirael's breath hitched. "What is it, grand-mère? What's happening?"

Miriel sighed, her gaze distant. "I don't know, my dear. But something is stirring in the Webwood, and worse, beyond. The fey are starting to flee the Moonsea region. It's as if they're running from something."

A heavy silence settled over them, the weight of Miriel's words hanging in the air. A shiver ran down Lirael's spine.

"Lirael," Miriel began, her voice heavy with the gravity of the situation. "Merritt County must be warned. Their isolation leaves them vulnerable to what stirs in the Webwood, and beyond."

"Merritt County," Lirael murmured, her mind wandering back to the memory of her childhood visits. "I haven't travelled there since I was a child. I recall the lakes and woods. And the songbirds."

The corners of Miriel's lips twitched into a faint smile. "The Count-Regent of Merritt County is Bartleby Longtooth, from his seat at the Palace of Birdson."

At this, she chuckled lightly, the sound echoing warmly in the quiet room. "Iger would have cussed a blue streak if someone had told him his family would become nobility. He had no love for such."

Lirael absorbed her great-grandmother's words, a sense of resolve washing over her. "I will go to Merritt County, great-grandmother. I'll deliver your warning to Count Longtooth."

Merritt County was markedly different from the cityscape of Hillsfar. Its raw, bucolic beauty was a stark contrast to the refined elegance she was accustomed to.

At the heart of the county stood the Palace of Birdsong. Its beautiful flowing architecture and intricate stonework set it apart as a symbol of authority amidst the verdant farmland.

Upon reaching the palace, Lirael dismounted and approached the guards. "I am Lirael Scatterstar of Hillsfar. I bear an urgent message for Count Bartleby Longtooth from Lady Miriel Scatterstar," she declared, her voice firm. She stood tall, radiating the dignified presence of her lineage as she awaited their response.

The audience chamber was an intimidating place, not because of its grandeur, but because of the man who occupied it. Cadmus Callahan, chief advisor to Count Bartleby Longtooth, was a one-eyed half-elf whose presence radiated an unsettling aura. Lirael felt a chill in the room as soon as he looked at her, his remaining eye piercingly cold.

"Miss Scatterstar," Cadmus started, the title devoid of respect, "your claim of urgent messages and noble lineage hold no particular sway here. The Count-Regent is a busy man and won't be disturbed with every missive that blows in from Hillsfar."

After Cadmus' words, an icy silence descended upon the audience chamber. Lirael's emerald eyes met Cadmus's single, frosty gaze unflinchingly. The silence lingered for a moment before Lirael spoke, her voice steady, yet edged with a quiet defiance.

"I see," she began, her words echoing in the high-ceilinged room. "Then perhaps, Master Callahan, you would inform the Count-Regent that a Scatterstar has returned to Merritt County after all these years, bringing news from Lady Miriel herself. I do hope that he can find a moment to spare from his busy schedule to hear what she has to say."

Cadmus's expression remained unchanged, his eye seemingly looking through her rather than at her. "As I've said, Miss Scatterstar, the Count-Regent has many pressing concerns. Your message will be delivered when the time is appropriate."

Lirael gave a curt nod, a cold smile playing on her lips. "Very well, Master Callahan. I trust you will ensure that my message reaches the Count. For the good of Merritt County, I can only hope that the 'appropriate time' does not come too late."

With that, she turned on her heel, her elegant exit doing nothing to hide the simmering anger beneath her composed exterior. Cadmus was left in the silence of the audience chamber, her words hanging heavily in the air.

As Lirael stepped back into the sunlight, the grandeur of the Palace of Birdsong felt more distant than ever. She looked back at the imposing structure, her gaze drawn to the very room she had been dismissed from. For a moment, she stood there, processing the conversation that had transpired, the sting of Cadmus Callahan's indifference still fresh in her mind.

Frustration welled within her, a bitter taste on her tongue. She was a Scatterstar. Her lineage commanded respect and her family had always stood for the greater good. To be dismissed so easily, her warning belittled... it was a blow to her pride, and a dishonor to the urgent message she carried.

She felt a simmering anger at Cadmus, his frosty demeanor and dismissive words. Who was he to decide the fate of a county, to ignore the warnings from one of the oldest noble families of the Moonsea region?

Yet, amidst her frustration, Lirael felt a spark of determination. Cadmus may have closed one door, but there were others still open. Her great-grandmother's old ties to the Baron Voight echoed in her mind, a beacon of hope in this unanticipated setback.

"I am a Scatterstar," she murmured to herself, a reaffirmation of her strength and resolve. "I will find another way. For the good of Merritt County...for the good of all the Moonsea region."

Her decision made, she mounted her horse once again, setting off for Voighton. Her encounter with Cadmus was a setback, indeed, but she was far from defeated. She had a warning to deliver, and she would be heard, one way or another. The journey ahead would be challenging, but she was ready. After all, she was a Scatterstar.

Baroness Voight sat in her study. A footman knocked softly, to let her Ladyship know that a Lady Lirael Scatterstar was requesting an audience. A descendant of Lady Miriel, then. It had been some time.

The Baroness remembered when she was barely out of girlhood and Miriel last visited their court. The elder Scatterstar had been ancient even then, a figure as old as the legends, her emerald eyes shining with an ageless wisdom.

The Baroness remembered her father, the Baron, conferring with Lady Miriel in hushed tones, their heads bent together over maps and letters. But Miriel had also spared time for the young Baroness, treating her with a respect that was often missing in those who interacted with a girl who had yet to see her second decade. She remembered Miriel's warm smile and her stories of ancient times, the Battle for Hillsfar, Edric I's founding of the empire, that captivated a young girl's imagination.

A ripple of unease ran through the Baroness. Miriel was long-lived even by elven standards, old even when Edric I was born. Her family was important in Hillsfar, and held important ties to the feyfolk in the wilds of the region.

For a Scatterstar to emerge now, requesting an audience, the Baroness couldn't help but see this as an omen. The old ties between their families held firm, yet the arrival of Lirael filled her with a

sense of foreboding. Why had the Scatterstars returned after all this time? What news did they bring?

Collecting herself, the Baroness straightened in her chair. Whatever the reason for Lirael's visit, she would receive her. The past demanded it, and the present, with all its uncertainties, might very well require it. She signaled her attendant to usher in the young Scatterstar, ready to face what the future had brought to her doorstep.

Baroness Voight sat across from Lady Lirael at a private dining table, the two women enveloped in the soft glow of the chandelier overhead. The atmosphere was elegant, yet intimate, a delicate balance that mirrored their conversation.

"Lady Scatterstar," the Baroness began, "We are so pleased that you have chosen to visit our Barony. I hope your family is well and that things in Hillsfar are running smoothly?"

Lirael smiled, a flicker of mirth lighting her emerald eyes. "Hillsfar has stood for a long time. My family enjoys the politics of the city more than I. I share my grandmother's wild soul, and prefer the countryside."

"Ah, I know exactly what you mean, albeit in a different fashion," the Baroness replied, her gaze distant for a moment as she remembered the feel of the wind in her hair and the rhythm of a horse beneath her. "But I am too old to engage in my fonest passion: riding out to meet a worthy enemy on the field of battle."

"There is much need for seasoned soldiers on the battlefield, Ladyship. I'm sure your experience in the field is invaluable." Lirael responded.

Baroness Voight glanced at the young elf sharply, a woman nearly twice her age, but saw no mockery in her eyes. She smiled and nodded. "Someone taught this one respect for her elders," she thought, "even those far younger than her."

"As you know, your family was instrumental in arranging for the magical fortitude of our very own Voightwood," the Baroness continued, her gaze growing serious. "We would not have the successful lumber operation that we have without the assistance of the Fey."

"The Scatterstars have long been friends of the good fey," Lirael responded. "However something is moving in the land. The fey, good and fell, are leaving the Moonsea. I brought my grandmother's warning to your Count, but his man turned me away like a commoner. I do not wish to speak ill of your Lord, but his house appears to be in thrall of a low churl."

The Baroness's gaze turned pensive, a hint of unease creeping into her features. After a moment of silence, she broke it. "Sadly, I am not surprised to hear this. Your family deserves to be heeded. Have you heard we have a new Lord here in Merrit county? I believe Lord Bettany would be very interested to hear what you have to say. As it happens. One of his chief advisers is here with us. She arrived just tonight."

"House Bettany! Of course, my mother was very fond of the late Lady Bettany, and was sad to hear of her passing," Lirael said, a note of sorrow slipping into her voice.

The rest of their conversation spiraled into revelations and shared concerns, punctuated by moments of unease and weighted pauses. The implications of the disappearing Fey, the decline in lumber output, the tales of dark deeds... all seemed to intertwine, painting a grim picture of the trials the region faced. As the night wore on, it became clear that Lirael's arrival was more than just a courtesy visit; it was a call to arms, a harbinger of the trials to come.

Finally, as the last of their food was cleared away and the candlelight waned, the Baroness posed a question, "I wonder if you might be willing to attend the Helpmoot I have called for tomorrow? Lady Marsk will be there and, I hope, Baron Steele."

"Of course," Lirael agreed. "I came to provide these warnings to our friends of old in the county. They will likely know if similar disturbances have become common in the wild places around Stavys and Penaris."

With that, the night ended, leaving both women with the ominous feeling that they were on the brink of significant changes. Lirael's mission was clear, and the challenges ahead were mounting. But they had each other, and that would have to be enough.